

Week 2 / Tuesday

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Ancient Greek Rhetoric

- ▶ The Classical Era of Athens: 508 BC – 322 BC
- ▶ Socrates: ca. 470 BC – 399 BC
- ▶ Plato: ca. 428 BC – 348 BC
- ▶ Aristotle: 384 BC – 322 BC

Plato, Socrates, and Aristotle

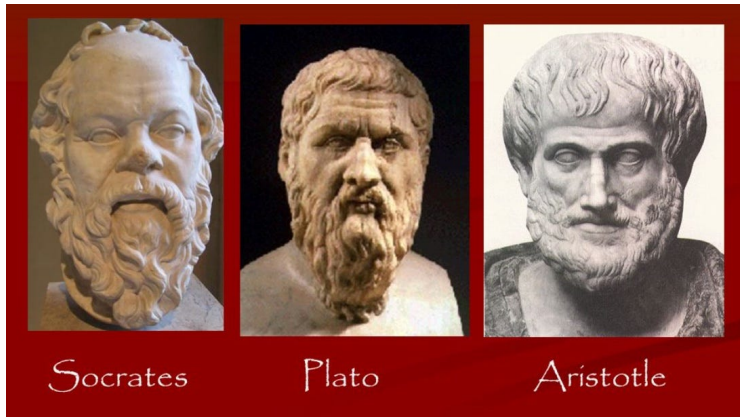


Figure: Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle are (arguably) the three most important theorists of rhetoric in the Western tradition.

Why Ancient Greece Matters

- ▶ Democracy
- ▶ Philosophy
- ▶ Rhetoric

Ancient Greek Rhetoric: Context

- ▶ The Trivium
 - ▶ Grammar
 - ▶ Logic
 - ▶ Rhetoric
- ▶ The Sophists: First teachers of rhetoric

Critiques of Rhetoric

- ▶ Is it moral?
- ▶ What are the potential negative effects?

Rhetoric and Manipulation



Figure: Rhetoric, like the Force, can be used for good and for evil.

Aristotle

- ▶ Rhetoric is a tool to arrive at truth and goodness
- ▶ The purpose of rhetoric is to identify the possibilities for persuasion within a given situation.

Rhetoric's Three Domains

- ▶ **Deliberative:** What should we do? (Political)
- ▶ **Forensic:** What happened? (Legal)
- ▶ **Epideictic:** Where do we put praise and blame? (Social/political)

The Four Primary Rhetorical Appeals

- ▶ **Ethos:** Appeals to an audience's sense of character. *What are ways that you assess the character of a speaker or writer?*
- ▶ **Pathos:** Appeals to an audience's sense of feeling, passion, or emotion. *What examples of pathos appeals can you think of?*
- ▶ **Logos:** Appeals to an audience's sense of logic/reasoning, such as facts, statistics, quotes, testimonials, etc. *What sorts of logos appeals do you find most persuasive?*
- ▶ **Kairos:** Appeals to an audience's sense of time and place. *Can you think of failures in terms of Kairos?*

Kairotic Failure



Figure: The celebrity "imagine" video was certainly a failure to understand the moment.

Where to Apply Rhetoric

- ▶ Situations where there are **legitimate** multiple sides to an issue.
- ▶ Situations in which you need to communicate effectively.
- ▶ Situations in which you need to analyze the arguments of others.

Aristotelian Analysis

1. Considering the context of a situation: audience, relevant facts, time-period, etc.
2. Examining the text and how it presents its argument, most specifically by...
3. Identifying the use of the primary rhetorical strategies (ethos, pathos, logos, and kairos), that are used to make the argument more or less persuasive.
4. Making an argument about whether the text should be believed based on points 1-3.